

FRAMEWORK OF ACCOUNTABILITY FOR SECURITY

A Corporate Governance Approach to Security Responsibility

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1. PURPOSE

The purpose of this framework is to establish clear accountability for security across all levels of an organization. It ensures that security is recognized as a strategic governance responsibility rather than an isolated operational function delegated solely to the Corporate Security Manager.

2. WHY SECURITY ACCOUNTABILITY MATTERS

Security failures often occur not because organizations lack security personnel, but because responsibilities are unclear, fragmented, or not supported by leadership.

Common consequences of poor security accountability include:

- Inadequate security budgets
- Delayed implementation of security recommendations
- Lack of ownership for identified vulnerabilities
- Weak coordination during crises
- Inconsistent compliance with security policies
- Increased operational, legal, financial, and reputational risk

A formal accountability framework helps ensure that security decisions are made at the appropriate level and that responsibilities are clearly assigned.

3. GUIDING PRINCIPLES

The framework is based on the following principles:

Security is a Leadership Responsibility

The Board and senior management are ultimately responsible for ensuring that appropriate security measures are in place.

Security is a Shared Responsibility

Every department and employee has a role in maintaining a secure environment.

Security Must Be Integrated into Business Operations

Security considerations should be incorporated into strategic planning, operations, HR processes, procurement, technology, and crisis management.

Accountability Must Be Clear

Roles, responsibilities, authorities, and reporting lines should be formally documented and communicated.

4. GOVERNANCE STRUCTURE

Board of Directors

The Board provides strategic oversight of security and organizational resilience.

Responsibilities:

- Approve security governance policies.
 - Review major security risks and mitigation strategies.
 - Ensure adequate resources are allocated for security.
 - Monitor security performance and significant incidents.
 - Promote a culture of accountability and risk awareness.
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Chief Executive Officer (CEO)

The CEO is accountable for ensuring that security is integrated into organizational strategy and operations.

Responsibilities:

- Demonstrate leadership commitment to security.
- Ensure security objectives align with business objectives.

- Support implementation of security policies and recommendations.
 - Ensure cross-functional cooperation on security matters.
 - Allocate sufficient resources for security programs.
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Senior Management

Senior leaders are accountable for security within their respective functions.

Responsibilities:

- Implement security policies within their departments.
 - Address identified vulnerabilities and risks.
 - Support security awareness and training.
 - Ensure employees comply with security procedures.
 - Participate in crisis management and business continuity planning.
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Corporate Security Manager / Security Department

The Corporate Security Manager serves as the subject matter expert and coordinator for security activities.

Responsibilities:

- Conduct Security Risk Assessments.
- Develop security policies, procedures, and standards.
- Provide security advice to management.
- Monitor threats and vulnerabilities.
- Coordinate incident response and investigations.
- Conduct security audits and awareness programs.
- Report security risks and recommendations to management.

Important Clarification:

The Corporate Security Manager is responsible for **advising, coordinating, monitoring, and reporting** on security matters. They are **not solely accountable for all security outcomes**, particularly when risks require decisions or resources controlled by other departments or senior leadership.

5. FUNCTIONAL ACCOUNTABILITY

Human Resources (HR)

HR plays a critical role in personnel security and organizational culture.

Responsibilities:

- Conduct background verification in accordance with applicable laws and policies.
 - Support employee vetting processes.
 - Promote ethical conduct and integrity.
 - Manage disciplinary processes related to security violations.
 - Support security awareness and training programs.
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Information Technology (IT)

IT is accountable for protecting digital systems and supporting cyber-physical security integration.

Responsibilities:

- Implement cybersecurity controls.
 - Protect networks, systems, and data.
 - Monitor for cyber threats and vulnerabilities.
 - Support incident response for cyber-related events.
 - Coordinate with Corporate Security on integrated security risks.
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Operations

Operational departments are accountable for implementing security controls within their activities.

Responsibilities:

- Comply with security policies and procedures.
 - Protect operational assets and facilities.
 - Report security incidents and vulnerabilities.
 - Support emergency response and business continuity measures.
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Facilities Management

Facilities Management is accountable for maintaining physical security infrastructure.

Responsibilities:

- Maintain access control systems.
- Ensure CCTV, alarms, and other security systems are functional.
- Manage perimeter security and building safety measures.

- Support emergency evacuation procedures.
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Legal and Compliance

Legal and Compliance functions ensure that security practices meet regulatory and contractual requirements.

Responsibilities:

- Advise on legal implications of security incidents.
 - Ensure compliance with applicable laws and regulations.
 - Support investigations and evidence preservation.
 - Review contracts for security-related obligations.
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Procurement and Supply Chain

Procurement is accountable for incorporating security considerations into vendor selection and supply chain management.

Responsibilities:

- Conduct security due diligence on vendors.
 - Include security requirements in contracts.
 - Monitor supplier compliance with security standards.
 - Address supply chain security risks.
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6. EMPLOYEE ACCOUNTABILITY

Every employee has a responsibility to contribute to a secure workplace.

Responsibilities:

- Follow security policies and procedures.
 - Protect company assets and information.
 - Report suspicious activities, incidents, or vulnerabilities.
 - Participate in security awareness training.
 - Maintain confidentiality and ethical conduct.
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7. SECURITY ACCOUNTABILITY MATRIX

Function	Key Security Accountability
Board of Directors	Strategic oversight and resource approval
CEO	Organizational security leadership
Senior Management	Departmental implementation of security controls
Corporate Security Manager	Security risk assessment, advice, coordination, and monitoring
HR	Personnel security and integrity management
IT	Cybersecurity and digital asset protection
Operations	Operational security compliance
Facilities	Physical security infrastructure
Legal/Compliance	Regulatory and legal security compliance
Procurement	Vendor and supply chain security
Employees	Adherence to security policies and reporting

8. ESCALATION AND DECISION-MAKING

Security risks should be escalated according to their severity and potential impact.

Escalation Levels

Risk Level	Escalation Requirement
Low	Department Manager
Moderate	Corporate Security Manager
High	Senior Management
Critical	CEO and Board

Security recommendations requiring significant resources or strategic decisions should be reviewed and approved at the appropriate management level.

9. REPORTING AND MONITORING

The framework should include regular reporting mechanisms, such as:

- Security risk assessment reports
- Incident reports
- Security audit findings
- Compliance reports
- Security performance indicators
- Status of corrective actions

Senior management and the Board should receive periodic updates on significant security risks and mitigation efforts.

10. ACCOUNTABILITY FOR SECURITY RECOMMENDATIONS

A common weakness in organizations is that security recommendations are identified but not implemented.

To address this, each recommendation should have:

- A designated owner.
- A target completion date.
- Required resources identified.
- Progress monitored and reported.
- Escalation procedures for overdue actions.

This ensures that identified risks are actively managed rather than remaining unresolved.

11. SECURITY CULTURE

A strong security culture is essential for effective accountability.

Organizations should:

- Promote security as a shared responsibility.
 - Encourage reporting of concerns without fear of retaliation.
 - Recognize and reinforce secure behaviors.
 - Provide regular security awareness training.
 - Demonstrate visible leadership commitment to security.
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12. REVIEW AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

The accountability framework should be reviewed periodically to ensure it remains relevant and effective.

Reviews should consider:

- Organizational changes
 - Emerging threats
 - Security incidents
 - Audit findings
 - Regulatory changes
 - Lessons learned from exercises and crises
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13. CONCLUSION

Security cannot be effective when it is treated as the sole responsibility of the Corporate Security Manager. A resilient organization requires a clear framework of accountability in which the Board, CEO, senior management, functional departments, and employees all understand and fulfill their security responsibilities.

The Corporate Security Manager plays a vital leadership and advisory role, but security success depends on organizational commitment, adequate resources, and active participation from all stakeholders.

By establishing clear accountability, organizations can strengthen governance, improve risk management, enhance operational resilience, and create a culture in which security is recognized as a fundamental business responsibility.

"Security is not the responsibility of one department alone; it is a collective obligation that requires leadership commitment, organizational accountability, and shared vigilance at every level."